of British rule in India, was a friend of Tilak, and was a champion of self-government for India. In late 1907 he travelled across India. Towards the end of his tour, described by his biographer as ‘a major episode in his career’, he travelled down south.[161] First arriving at Tirunelveli from Madras, Hardie was received by K.R. Guruswami Aiyar and several other vakils. A day later, on 13 November, he arrived in Tuticorin by train, accompanied by the liberal leader, V.S. Srinivasa Sastri, and a Tirunelveli lawyer, T.V. Krishnaswamy Aiyar. Hardie was received with garlands. (VOC was travelling and was not therefore present at that time: whether the moderate coterie surrounding him would have permitted Hardie to meet VOC is doubtful.) A local band played a few bars of ‘See the Conquering Hero’ but soon switched to ‘God Save the King’. Hardie said he had been deputed by his party to give a patient hearing to the Indian people and report on their grievances. When he returned to England and related his experiences, he assured his audience, there would certainly be ‘an uproar in the House of Commons’. Promising to vote always in favour of the Indian people, Hardie however warned his audience not to expect too much. Calling for the next Congress session to be held in England, he advocated the continuance of the Swadeshi movement. Not incidentally, Gerald Christian Roche Victoria,[162] SSNCo’s manager at Colombo spoke on the occasion.[163] When Hardie left for Colombo that evening, he took the Swadeshi steamer rather than BI’s—a gesture pregnant with symbolism.[164] A full-fledged procession was organized from the Cosmopolitan Club, where Hardie was lodged, and the pier where a well-decorated *Miranda* was ready to convey him to the *Lawoe*. When the more than 150 people gathered to give him a farewell shouted ‘Vande Mataram’, Hardie too joined the chorus.[165] In the background of loud cheering and the enthusiastic waving of handkerchiefs, Hardie stood at the head of the ladder for a good while.[166]

Hardie’s Swadeshi voyage was the crowning moment of 1907 for SSNCo. Britain’s most prominent opposition leader had sent a political message. The mood in SSNCo’s camp was so buoyant that, if the Tuticorin